

A ticking time bomb!

For the past two decades, we've been dedicated to offering advice on gadgets and technology that can enhance your lives, with a primary focus on helping you make informed choices for your next tech purchase. However, today, we invite you to pause and contemplate the dark sides of gadget ownership. In this edition, we're raising the alarm regarding the imperative need for sustainable technology choices and eco-friendly tech practices, underlining the importance of integrating green technology into every aspect of our tech-driven lives. One critical facet of sustainable tech decisions and practices that have too long been neglected is the responsible management of electronic waste, aka e-waste, at the individual level. No, e-waste is not a topic exclusive to giant corporations and gadget manufacturers. Only by taking personal responsibility for our electronic waste can we collectively make a significant impact. Every small effort towards responsible e-waste management counts towards a more sustainable tech ecosystem and a better future.

While the Indian government has made commendable progress in refining regulations and policies concerning e-waste management, individual awareness, and intent remain far below the minimum threshold required to tackle this looming crisis. Take a moment to ponder: How many old, unused gadgets are gathering dust in your drawers? If you're like many of us, the count may be surprisingly high. In my case, it stands at seven outdated devices, and approximately 12 adapters and chargers, some of which no longer serve any purpose. They sit there, taking up space, with the vague hope that they might come in handy someday. It's not that I derive any joy from contributing to e-waste; it's the psychological reluctance to part with items that once represented a reasonable investment of hard-earned money. But it's high time we change this mindset, and here's why.

As a nation, India ranks as the third-largest producer of e-waste globally. By the end of 2023, we are on track to generate nearly 2 million tonnes of e-waste annually. To put this in perspective, the figure stood at 1.6 million tonnes in 2021-22. On average, each Indian contributes about 1.5 kilograms of e-waste every year. This



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Editor-in-Chief

waste includes old phones, adapters, laptops, tablets, washing machines, TVs, electronic kitchen appliances, personal grooming gadgets, and more. What makes this problem even more concerning is that these discarded devices often contain hazardous substances such as mercury, lead, and cadmium. If not disposed of responsibly, these substances can leach into the environment, contaminating it and posing a far greater threat than the vehicular pollution that we've been battling for years.

The major challenge we face when it comes to personal e-waste management is not a lack of knowledge about responsible disposal methods; it's our collective intent or rather, the lack thereof. A simple Google search can help us locate e-waste collection centers in our areas. Many of us can either visit these centers or even book a home collection online, making it incredibly convenient to dispose of e-waste responsibly. Moreover, electronics retail chains like Croma and Reliance Digital have established e-waste collection sections to facilitate this process. It's remarkable how a small effort towards responsible e-waste disposal can have a significant impact.

The solution is right before us; all we need to do is acknowledge the problem of e-waste and commit to disposing of it responsibly rather than simply handing it over to local scrap dealers.

As an action step, I've rallied my apartment residents to join me in a self-driven effort toward e-waste management. We're responsibly disposing away old laptops, smartphones, and electronic appliances by giving them to authorized e-waste management institutions for eco-friendly recycling and disposal. Let's declutter our lives of old gadgets, adapters, and chargers. Embracing timely disposal of e-waste as a responsibility is crucial in our tech-savvy lives. Together, we can defuse this ticking time bomb but the time for action is now, and it doesn't take a herculean effort to act on it.

What are you doing towards responsible e-waste management? Write to me at soham.raniga@digit.in with your views, ideas (and proposed actions) toward tackling e-waste management at an individual level. I'd love to see some support on this one. **d**



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